The Bāʿ Alawī Sāda: A Comprehensive History, Methodology, and Legacy (Part 3: Tarīm in the Age of the Companions, and Independent Testimony to the Lineage)

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1. The riddah in Ḥaḍramawt and the siege of al-Nujayr (documented in the classical histories). The Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم had appointed Ziyād ibn Labīd al-Bayāḍī al-Anṣārī رضي الله عنه governor over Kindah in Ḥaḍramawt, and Abū Bakr رضي الله عنه confirmed him. After the Prophet's صلى الله عليه وسلم death a part of Kindah, under its chieftain al-Ashʿath ibn Qays, refused the authority of the caliphate; Ziyād fought them, al-Muhājir ibn Abī Umayyah رضي الله عنه (governor of Ṣanʿāʾ) was ordered to reinforce him, and ʿIkrimah رحمه الله ibn Abī Jahl رضي الله عنه arrived with further forces. The rebels barricaded themselves in the fortress of al-Nujayr, which lies 30km from Tarim and was besieged and taken in the year 12H; al-Ashʿath was captured, brought to Madīnah, pardoned by Abū Bakr رضي الله عنه, and married to his sister Umm Farwah. The place is defined by Yāqūt al-Ḥamawī in Muʿjam al-Buldān (entry al-Nujayr, as reproduced in the Hawramani Arabic Lexicon): النُّجَيْرُ: حِصْنٌ بِالْيَمَنِ قُرْبَ حَضْرَمَوْتَ مَنِيعٌ لَجَأَ إِلَيْهِ أَهْلُ الرِّدَّةِ – "al-Nujayr: an impregnable fortress in Yemen near Ḥaḍramawt, to which the apostates took refuge."

2. Tarīm's steadfastness, and the duʿāʾ of Abū Bakr رضي الله عنه. The earliest source for this is the Ḥaḍramī historian ʿAbd al-Qādir ibn Shaykh ibn ʿAbdillāh al-ʿAydarūs رحمه الله (d. 1038H), al-Nūr al-Sāfir ʿan Akhbār al-Qarn al-ʿĀshir, in his entry on Tarīm. Writing of the city's merits, he says:

> وَيُقَالُ إِنَّ أَبَا بَكْرٍ الصِّدِّيقَ رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ دَعَا لَهَا بِثَلَاثِ دَعَوَاتٍ: أَنْ يَكْثُرَ بِهَا الصَّالِحُونَ، وَأَنْ يُبَارِكَ اللَّهُ فِيمَا بِهَا، وَأَنْ لَا تُطْفَأَ بِهَا نَارٌ إِلَى يَوْمِ الْقِيَامَةِ. وَمَعْنَاهُ: أَنْ لَا تَزَالَ عَامِرَةً إِلَى يَوْمِ الْقِيَامَةِ. وَذَلِكَ حِينَ بَلَغَهُ أَنَّ أَهْلَهَا لَمْ يَرْتَدُّوا كَغَيْرِهِمْ مِنَ الْعَرَبِ الَّذِينَ ارْتَدُّوا بَعْدَ مَوْتِ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ صلى الله عليه وسلم

> "It is said that Abū Bakr al-Ṣiddīq رضي الله عنه made three supplications for it (Tarim): that the righteous be many in it, that Allah bless what is in it, and that no fire be extinguished in it until the Day of Resurrection – meaning that it will remain inhabited until the Day of Resurrection. That was when word reached him that its people had not apostatised, as others of the Arabs did after the death of the Messenger of Allah صلى الله عليه وسلم."

For this reason one of the names of the city of Tarim still in vogue today is 'Madinah al Siddiq' (The City of (Abu Bakr) al Siddiq due to his three supplications that he made for it.

It is therefore a Tarīmī tradition – repeated often in variations, i.e the a duʿāʾ that the city be preserved to the end of time, that water be abundant, and that scholars come forth from it "like shoots after the rain"

3. Companions buried in Tarīm. In the same entry, al-ʿAydarūs رحمه الله writes, after describing the concentration of scholars in Tarīm:

> وَيُذْكَرُ أَنَّهَا تُنْبِتُ الصَّالِحِينَ كَمَا تُنْبِتُ الْأَرْضُ الْبَقْلَ، وَاجْتَمَعَ بِهَا فِي عَصْرٍ وَاحِدٍ مِنَ الْعُلَمَاءِ الَّذِينَ بَلَغُوا رُتْبَةَ الْإِفْتَاءِ ثَلَاثُمِائَةِ رَجُلٍ، وَأَنَّ بِمَقْبَرَتِهَا جَمَاعَةً مِمَّنْ شَهِدَ بَدْرًا مَعَ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ صلى الله عليه وسلم وَغَيْرِهِمْ مِنَ الصَّحَابَةِ رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُمْ، وَأَنَّ عَدَدَهُمْ سَبْعُونَ نَفَرًا، وَكَانَ الشَّيْخُ عَبْدُ الرَّحْمَنِ السَّقَّافُ رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ إِذَا زَارَ قُبُورَ تَرِيمَ يُشِيرُ إِلَى مَكَانِ قُبُورِهِمْ فِي مَحَلٍّ مَخْصُوصٍ هُنَاكَ

> "It is mentioned that it brings forth the righteous as the earth brings forth vegetation; that three hundred men who had reached the rank of issuing fatwā were gathered in it in a single age; and that in its cemetery are Companions who witnessedthe Battle of Badr with the Messenger of Allah صلى الله عليه وسلم and other Companions رضي الله عنهم, their number being seventy persons; and that Shaykh ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Saqqāf رحمه الله, when he visited the graves of Tarīm, would point to the place of their graves, in a specific spot there."

He continues: وَرُوِيَ عَنْهُ أَنَّهُ قَالَ: فِي تُرْبَةِ آلِ أَبَا عَلَوِيٍّ ثَمَانُونَ قُطْبًا كُلُّهُمْ أَشْرَافٌ — "and it is related from him that he said: in the burial-ground of the Āl Abā ʿAlawī are eighty Quṭbs, all of them of Prophetic lineage".

4. Masjid al-Ribāṭ, Ḥārat al-Ruḍaymah, Tarīm. At the very spot which the Sahabah tied their mounts when entering Tarim was built a masjid of its namesake and oral tradition till today holds the transmission that this Masjid was built to commemorate the momentous moment of the arrival of the Sahabah to the city of Tarim

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Independent testimony to the lineage and rank of the Bā ʿAlawī – including Imām Yūsuf al-Nabhānī رحمه الله

The testimony of a tradition's own scholars to its rank, even sometimes necessary in order to acknowledge favour and distinction is understood (as is witnessed on much of what has been mentioned about Tarim and the Ba Alawi Sadah), however what carries even more weight is the testimony of scholars outside it. The best-attested independent statement is that of Shaykh Yūsuf ibn Ismāʿīl al-Nabhānī رحمه الله (d. 1350H), the Shāfiʿī judge and prolific author of Beirut, in the introduction to his Riyāḍ al-Jannah fī Adhkār al-Kitāb wa'l-Sunnah. It comes in a digression (istiṭrād) prompted by his meeting in Beirut with a Bā ʿAlawī of the Sādāh of Madīnah, Sayyid Zayn al-ʿĀbidīn Jamal al-Layl ibn ʿAbd al-Raḥmān Bā ʿAlawī, whose grandfather of the same name, the Muftī of Madīnah, had written Rāḥat al-Arwāḥ bi-Dhikr al-Fattāḥ, a work Shaykh al-Nabhānī borrowed from him and drew on. He then writes:

> اسْتِطْرَادٌ: إِنَّ سَادَاتِنَا آلَ بَاعَلَوِيٍّ — الَّذِينَ هَذَا الْفَاضِلُ مِنْهُمْ رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُمْ — قَدْ أَجْمَعَتِ الْأُمَّةُ الْمُحَمَّدِيَّةُ فِي سَائِرِ الْأَعْصَارِ وَالْأَقْطَارِ عَلَى أَنَّهُمْ مِنْ أَصَحِّ أَهْلِ بَيْتِ النُّبُوَّةِ نَسَبًا، وَأَثْبَتِهِمْ حَسَبًا، وَأَكْثَرِهِمْ عِلْمًا وَعَمَلًا وَفَضْلًا وَأَدَبًا، وَهُمْ كُلُّهُمْ مِنْ أَهْلِ السُّنَّةِ وَالْجَمَاعَةِ عَلَى مَذْهَبِ إِمَامِنَا الشَّافِعِيِّ رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ، مَعَ كَثْرَتِهِمْ إِلَى دَرَجَةٍ لَا يَقِلُّونَ فِيهَا عَنْ مِائَةِ أَلْفِ إِنْسَانٍ، وَمَعَ مُجَاوَرَةِ بِلَادِهِمْ، وَهِيَ بِلَادُ حَضْرَمَوْتَ، إِلَى الزَّيْدِيَّةِ فِي الْيَمَنِ، وَمَعَ تَفَرُّقِهِمْ فِي سَائِرِ الْبِلَادِ وَلَا سِيَّمَا بِلَادُ الْهِنْدِ. أَمَّا عُلَمَاؤُهُمُ الْكِبَارُ وَأَوْلِيَاؤُهُمُ الْأَخْيَارُ، أَصْحَابُ الْأَنْوَارِ وَالْأَسْرَارِ، فِي هَذَا الْعَصْرِ وَمَا تَقَدَّمَهُ مِنَ الْأَعْصَارِ، فَهُمْ أَكْثَرُ وَأَنْوَرُ مِنْ نُجُومِ السَّمَاءِ، بِهِمْ يَحْصُلُ لِكُلِّ مَنِ اقْتَدَى بِهِمُ الِاهْتِدَاءُ، وَلَا يَمْتَرِي فِي صِحَّةِ نَسَبِهِمْ وَكَثْرَةِ فَضَائِلِهِمْ وَمَزَايَاهُمُ الَّتِي تَمَيَّزُوا بِهَا عَنِ الْأَنَامِ بِبَرَكَةِ جَدِّهِمْ عَلَيْهِ الصَّلَاةُ وَالسَّلَامُ إِلَّا مَنْ قَلَّ حَظُّهُ فِي الْإِسْلَامِ

> "A digression: our masters the Āl Bā ʿAlawī – of whom this excellent man is one, may Allah be pleased with them – the Muḥammadan community, in all ages and lands, has agreed that they are among the soundest of the Ahl al-Bayt of the Prophethood in lineage, the most firmly established in descent [ḥasab], and the most abundant in knowledge, deed, virtue and refinement; that all of them are of Ahl al-Sunnah wa'l-Jamāʿah on the school of our imam al-Shāfiʿī, despite their numbers reaching a degree not below a hundred thousand people, despite the proximity of their land, Ḥaḍramawt, to the Zaydīs of Yemen, and despite their dispersal through all lands, especially India. As for their great scholars and their righteous saints, the possessors of lights and secrets, in this age and the ages before it, they are more numerous and more luminous than the stars of the sky; guidance is attained by everyone who follows them; and none doubts the soundness of their lineage and the abundance of their virtues and distinctions - by which they are distinguished from mankind by the blessing of their grandfather صلى الله عليه وسلم, - except one whose portion of faith in Islam is miniscule."

He then adds a first-hand attestation, in the same digression: he had read some of their works and found them "all guidance, polishing the rust from the heart"; had met some of them and found in them virtues and noble character "that fill the eyes with delight and the hearts with joy"; and had corresponded with some and found in their letters gentleness, humility and beauty of expression "such that a believer could not come to know it without loving its author deeply" – and that whatever praise he gave them, "it is less than what my heart holds for them of loyalty and belief in their perfection."

What his statement establishes, is that a leading Shāfiʿī scholar and author outside Ḥaḍramawt, who had read their books, met some of them and corresponded with others, held them to be among the soundest of the Prophet's صلى الله عليه وسلم descendants in lineage and among the most learned and devout, and Ash'ari in creed and Shāfiʿī in law.

Other independent testimonies: Dr. Muḥammad Abū Bakr Bādhīb, in praising the Ba Alawi Sadah also cites:

- Murtaḍā al-Zabīdī, the most famous commentator on the Ihya Ulum al Din of Imam Ghazali in (al-Rawḍ) describing Aḥmad ibn ʿĪsā al-Naqīb "al-Rūmī" as "the ancestor of this blessed lineage"

- Ibn Ḥajar al-Haytamī رحمه الله, in an ijāzah said to be dated 942H, on the combination of sharīʿah and ḥaqīqah among them; in his own collection of chains of transmission (al-Masānid), listing his Sufi teachers, Ibn Ḥajar al-Haytamī رحمه الله – names Abū Bakr al-ʿAydarūs رحمه الله among them and states, that the Bā ʿAlawī ṭarīqah is:

"جليلة عالية المقدار" (jalīlah ʿāliyat al-miqdār, "a venerable path of lofty standing"), and gives his own chain through it – ʿAbdullāh al-ʿAydarūs ← Abū Bakr al-ʿAydarūs ← ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Saqqāf ← Muḥammad ← ʿAlī ← ʿAlawī ← Muḥammad ← ʿAlī ← Muḥammad ← ʿAlī ← ʿAlawī ← Muḥammad ← ʿAlawī ← ʿUbaydillāh ← Aḥmad [al-Muhājir] ← ʿĪsā ← Muḥammad ← ʿAlī ← Jaʿfar al-Ṣādiq ← Muḥammad al-Bāqir ← Zayn al-ʿĀbidīn ← al-Ḥusayn ← ʿAlī ← the Messenger of Allah صلى الله عليه وسلم – the identical chain already given above from al-Manhaj al-Sawī and ʿIqd al-Yawāqīt.

- and Jaʿfar ibn Abī Bakr al-Labanī on their rigorous procedures for verifying their genealogies.

The same treatise sets out the formal juristic basis for accepting a documented sayyid lineage of this kind: a citation attributed to Ibn Rushd رحمه الله ("there is no disagreement on this") and to Imam Mālik رحمه الله (via Sīdī Khalīl's al-Tawḍīḥ and Ibn Khaldūn رحمه الله) that people are to be believed about their own lineage; a named fatwā from Shaykh Ibrāhīm al-Riyāḥī رحمه الله, head of the Mālikī council of North Africa, on establishing noble lineage (sharaf) through samāʿ (received oral report) where it is unanimous and uncontested; and the listing of lineage (nasab) among the matters classical fiqh accepts as established by istifāḍah (widespread repute) alone, in both Ibn Ḥajar al-Haytamī رحمه الله's own Tuḥfah and the Ḥanafī Radd al-Muḥtār, alongside death, waqf, marriage, and judicial appointment.

Two further named historical fatwās are cited specifically endorsing the Bā ʿAlawī written genealogical register (shajarah) as reliable:

- al-ʿAllāmah ʿAlī ibn ʿUmar al-ʿArshānī رحمه الله ruled that a judge, muftī, or witness may rely on the known Āl ʿAlawī shajarah for lineage testimony without requiring a full chain, treating it like istifāḍah;
- and Sayyid Abū Bakr ibn Aḥmad Bāfaqīh رحمه الله, asked whether one may rely on the shajarah authored by Shaykh ʿAbdullāh al-ʿAydarūs رحمه الله, ruled yes – co-signed by two further named jurists – on the grounds that its compiler was a trustworthy scholar who spoke only with knowledge and proof.

The treatise also records a specific historical verification episode: during a period when the lineage connection was disputed, the sādah sent the ḥāfiẓ Sayyid al-Ḥasan ʿAlī ibn Zayn Ḥaydar to Iraq specifically to re-verify it with witnesses, after which — the treatise states — pilgrims from Ḥaḍramawt attested to it as well as was done earlier by the son of Al-Muhajir Ahmad bin Isa, Ubaydullah who went he went back to Makkah and Basra to collect testimonies and witnesses to their lineage when some detractors doubted the lineage of Al Muhajir Ahmad bin Isa after his arrival in Hadramwt.

The fiqh maxim unanimously agreed upon is: al-nās muʾminūn ʿalā ansābihim ("people are to be believed regarding their own lineages" — the burden of proof falls on whoever disputes a lineage, failing which the objector himself becomes liable as a qādhif, a slanderer):

> إن أمة الإسلام أمة الإسناد، واختصت بهذه الصفة عن سائر الأمم، ونقل إلينا القرآن الكريم بالإسناد، ونقلت إلينا السنة المطهرة بالإسناد، وكذا التواريخ والأنساب والمغازي والسير؛ وإذا تركنا لكل شخص أن يطلق لسانه فيما ثبت سيتمادى بهم الأمر إلى تكذيب كثير من الأحكام الشرعية والحوادث التاريخية لكونها لم تعجبهم ولم توافق هواهم... وهو أن الناس مؤمنون على أنسابهم، فمن ثبت نسبه وطعن فيه غيره فعليه الإثبات بالبينة، وإلا يُعَدّ باعتباره قاذفاً

> "The Muslim community is, [above all,] the community of 'chains of transmission' (isnād), a quality that distinguishes it from every other nation. The Noble Qurʾān was conveyed to us by isnād, the purified Sunnah was conveyed to us by isnād, and likewise history, genealogy, military campaigns, and biography (were conveyed by Isnad). If we allowed every person free rein to speak against what is [already] established, matters would proceed to denying many legal rulings and historical events, simply because it does not please them or suit their inclination... and [the governing principle is] that people are to be believed regarding their own lineages: whoever has an established lineage, and is impugned by another, the burden of proof by clear evidence falls on the objector — failing which he is to be reckoned a slanderer."

To be continued in sha Allah...

Read online: https://mahwa-al-rusum.github.io/a/2026-10-21-ba-alawi-sada-part-3-tarim-companions-and-independent-testimony/